1 · THE AD

A 15-second storyboard

Portrait 9:16, readable with the sound off: the payoff first (one turn, six clears), then the rule, then the cog that sets the game apart, then a challenge the viewer wants to answer.

0–2 s · Hook

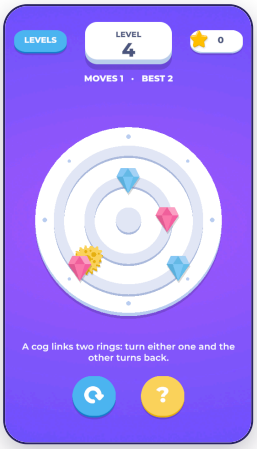


One turn lines up all six colours; six spokes clear together.

ONE TURN. SIX CLEARS.

Sound: Gear click, six pops

2–4 s · The rule

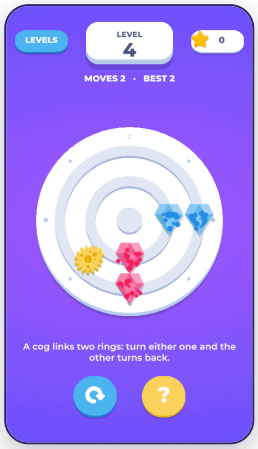


A finger turns a ring; red and blue gems move closer to a line.

LINE UP ONE COLOUR

Sound: Turn tick

4–6 s · The twist



The next turn: the cog turns the neighbour back, and a red and a blue spoke clear.

COGS TURN BOTH

Sound: Gear whirr, pop

6–8 s · The chain

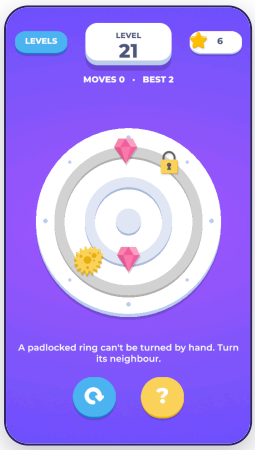


Three cogs: one turn moves all four rings.

ONE TURN, EVERY RING

Sound: Rising whirr

8–9.5 s · The lock



A tap on the padlocked ring: it wiggles and refuses.

LOCKED? TURN ITS NEIGHBOUR

Sound: Clunk

9.5–11 s · Challenge



A full board of 24 gems: level 34.

BEST: 8 MOVES. CAN YOU?

Sound: Music drops

11–13.5 s · Payoff

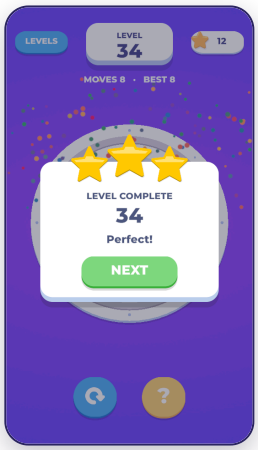


Level 14's last turn: four colours line up at once and pop.

BRILLIANT!

Sound: Pops climbing in pitch

13.5–15 s · End card



Three stars and confetti; the edit lays the title and a Play button over it.

CLOCKWORK · PLAY FREE

Sound: Win jingle

Every frame is real. A PlayMode test (`AdStoryboard_CapturesTheBeats`) plays levels 4, 14, 21 and 34 with the solver's moves and saves a frame a beat after every move; these are picked from them. The challenge line quotes the level's real par.

2 · THE CPI TEST

Three hooks, one decision

A hyper-casual prototype's first question is not "is it fun?" but "will people install it cheaply enough?"

Creative variants

VARIANT	FIRST 2 SECONDS	WHAT IT TESTS
A · Payoff (above)	One turn clears six spokes at once	The genre's satisfying clear; the widest audience
B · Challenge	A full board and "Best: 8 moves. Can you?"	Puzzle players who want to beat a number
C · The cog	Close-up: a turn spins a chain of cogs and every ring moves	Is the cog itself the hook? (the game's difference)

Test design

	SETTING (PLANNING ASSUMPTIONS)
Channels	Meta (Facebook/Instagram) first; an ad network after a pass
Geo and build	US Android, the APK behind a store listing with analytics on
Rounds	Up to three creative rounds before the kill decision; change the hook first, as it is the cheapest
Reading	Compare variants only once each has enough impressions for its CTR to settle

Go / iterate / kill

Go

- CPI under $0.30 [1]
- CTR above 2% [2]
- IPM above 80 on Android [2]
- D1 at least 38% on Android [1]
- Day-7 playtime per user over 2,000 s [1]

Soft launch with the KPI plan overleaf.

Iterate

- CTR good but CPI over the line: the store page loses them (icon, first screenshot)
- CPI good but D1 short: the first minute (levels 1–5) loses them
- Neither: try the next hook

Kill

- After three creative rounds, no variant within reach of the go line on CPI
- Or D1 stays near the genre median (19% on Android [3]) even with a good CPI

The idea is not landing: test a new theme for the same rules before more content.

Where the lines come from. The go thresholds are quoted from publishers' published guidance (sources below). For scale: across hyper-casual games in Q3 2022, the median Android D1 was 19% and the top 2% reached 42% [3]. Each publisher sets its own lines; these are a starting point, to be replaced by the publisher's own benchmarks.

[1] Supersonic: "The 3 most important KPIs for testing your hyper-casual prototype", supersonic.com/learn/blog/the-3-most-important-kpis-for-testing-your-hyper-casual-prototype

[2] Ivan Fedyanin (Ducky), PocketGamer.biz, 17 June 2021: "What are the key KPIs for a successful hypercasual game?", pocketgamer.biz/comment-and-opinion/76718/ducky-ivan-fedyanin-key-hypercasual-kpis

[3] Tenjin and GameAnalytics, Q3 2022: "Hypercasual benchmarks (via Game Dev Reports, 11 October 2022)", gamedevreports.substack.com/p/tenjin-and-gameanalytics-hypercasual

3 · KPI PLAN

What to measure, and what to change

The prototype has no analytics yet. These are the events to add, each tied to a question the design needs answered.

EVENT (TO ADD)	FIELDS	ANSWERS
`level_start`	level, attempt	Where players stop (the level funnel)
`level_win`	level, moves, par, stars, seconds, hints	Is the curve right? Moves over par per level
`hint_used`	level, move_number	Which levels are walls, and at which move
`restart`	level, moves	Lost players start over before they quit
`turn_refused`	level, ring	Do players understand padlocks (levels 21–23)?
`session_start`	day_since_install, level	Retention (D1, D7)

KPIs and targets

KPI	TARGET OR BENCHMARK	IF IT MISSES
D1 retention	≥ 38% Android [1]	The first minute: levels 1–5, the first cog (4–5)
D7 retention	Benchmark: the top 2% of hyper-casual reach 16% on Android [3]	Chapter pacing; the walls the funnel shows
Hints on levels 4–5	Set from the first cohort	Players don't read the 2:1 cog: rework its tip and drawing
Refused turns on 21–23	Set from the first cohort	Padlocks read as broken, like one-way cogs did
Moves over par	Compare with the bots (workbook)	Where people and bots disagree, people are right: retune

Watch these levels first

The greedy bot (workbook) earns 3 stars least often on: **6 Same Colour Twice, 16 Twins, 19 The Big Wheel, 25 Deep Breath, 32 Mainspring, 33 Pendulum**. Bots aren't people, but these are the first places to look in the funnel and the hint data.

Nothing guessed

Targets with a source carry its number; the rest are set from the first real cohort instead of guessed. The bots' curve in the workbook is the baseline the real data is read against.

[1] Supersonic: "The 3 most important KPIs for testing your hyper-casual prototype", supersonic.com/learn/blog/the-3-most-important-kpis-for-testing-your-hyper-casual-prototype

[2] Ivan Fedyanin (Ducky), PocketGamer.biz, 17 June 2021: "What are the key KPIs for a successful hypercasual game?", pocketgamer.biz/comment-and-opinion/76718/ducky-ivan-fedyanin-key-hypercasual-kpis

[3] Tenjin and GameAnalytics, Q3 2022: "Hypercasual benchmarks (via Game Dev Reports, 11 October 2022)", gamedevreports.substack.com/p/tenjin-and-gameanalytics-hypercasual